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The Mother-Daughter Plot in Toni Morrison's *God Help the Child*

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ABSTRACT
This essay analyzes the representation of motherhood in Toni Morrison's last novel, *God Help the Child* (2015). While previous critical responses have favoured a sociological perspective emphasising the intersectionality of class, gender and race, my own reading is articulated as an attempt to bridge the gap between the sociological and the narratological, by attending to narrative construction. First, it contextualises the representation of mother characters in Morrison's *oeuvre*. This is furthered into a wider consideration of the sociological matrix in which these representations originate, with an emphasis on black feminist thought about motherhood. Finally, this essay explores the narrative construction of the mother character in *God Help the Child*, and its ethical dimension. Focalisation and narrative progression are identified as the building blocks through which Morrison subverts conventional patterns associated to the mother-daughter plot as theorised by Marianne Hirsch (1989), and the impact of such narrative construction on the reader's ethical judgment is addressed.

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1. Introduction

This essay analyzes the representation of motherhood in Toni Morrison's last published novel, *God Help the Child* (2015). First, it contextualises such representation in connection to Morrison's *oeuvre*, starting from the hypothesis that mother characters in her fiction are always troubled and troubling ones. This is furthered into a wider consideration of the sociological matrix in which these representations originate, with an emphasis on black feminist thought about motherhood. Against the grain of articulations on motherhood deeply indebted to white American second wave feminism, thinkers like hooks, Washington and Collins have postulated two key views of black motherhood: first, the refusal to perceive motherhood and domestic work as crippling to female development, and second, the acknowledgment that the institutionalised ideal of the "natural mother" as a selfless, nurturing being becomes enormously problematic in a racist context. Finally, this essay takes cue from Marianne Hirsch's seminal study on the "mother-daughter plot"[1] in order to analyse the narrative construction of the mother character in *God Help the Child*, and its ethical dimension. After identifying Morrison's

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[1]Hirsch, *The Mother/Daughter Plot*.

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management of focalisation and narrative progression as key narrative devices through which Morrison subverts conventional patterns associated to the mother-daughter plot, my essay assesses the impact of such narrative construction on the reader's transforming ethical judgment of the characters and situations narrated.

God Help the Child is a story of personal crisis and maturation, focused on Bride, née Lula Ann Bridewell, a young, successful fashion executive. Upon its publication, reviewers of the novel pointed to its fairytale tone,[2] drawing connections to stories like "Cinderella" or "The Ugly Duckling". This is somehow confirmed by the text itself, as it offers a summary of its storyline that suggests such fairytale patterning: "the fairytale castle collapsed into the mud and sand on which its vanity was built".[3] Kara Walker noticed such fairytale elements, emphasising the female coming of age storyline,[4] but ignoring the presence of the evil mother figure. In *God Help the Child*, the bad mother features prominently, in the figure of Sweetness. Others, like López Ramírez have read the character as emblematic of the "crone" or witch figure in traditional fairytales.[5] In Morrison's contemporary rendering, this figure is characterised as an abusive mother.

As noted by Jesse A. Goldberg, Sweetness's bad mothering "may indeed be strong enough to qualify as emotional abuse".[6] Among her faults as a mother, we may include attempted murder (when she presses a blanket over her newborn baby's face[7]), physical punishment ("slap my face or spank me"[8]), verbal abuse ("her screaming at me was the worst"[9]), emotional abuse (as when Bride has her first menses[10]), or asking her daughter to lie about her witnessing the landlord's abuse of another child ("when I told Sweetness what I had seen, she was furious"[11]).

Yet, while most critical readings of the novel take as their departure point the acknowledgement of Sweetness as a "bad mother",[12] many point to the ethically troubling representation of this character in the text. Sweetness may be a "bad mother", yet she is one whose motives may be understood, if not fully absolved. Delphine Gras' depiction is paradigmatic of this critical position: "While Morrison does not excuse Sweetness's behavior, she neither stigmatizes her character nor black mothers in general". Thus, Gras claims "Morrison thus cautions against the demonization of black mothers".[13] Both Gras and Evelyn Jaffe Schreiber read Sweetness from the perspective of trauma. In the latter's account, she is meant to be perceived as equally traumatised as her daughter, making her pass from the role of perpetrator to victim: "Morrison sets up the reader as the outside witness for Sweetness, calling on the reader to accept her testimony and address her trauma as well as the trauma she has heaped upon her

[2]Balter, "Review *God Help the Child*"; Kara Walker, "Review of Toni Morrison's 'God Help the Child'", *The New York Times* (19 April 2015).
[3]Morrison, *God Help the Child*, 135.
[4]Walker, n.p.
[5]López Ramírez, "The New Witch in Toni Morrison's *Song of Solomon* and *God Help the Child*".
[6]Goldberg, "From Sweetness to Toya Graham".
[7]Morrison, *God Help*, 5.
[8]Ibid., 31.
[9]Ibid.
[10]Ibid., 79.
[11]Ibid., 54.
[12]See for instance Gallego, "Childhood Traumas, Journeys".
[13]Gras, "Revisiting the Past in the Age of Posts".

daughter".[14] My reading of *God Help the Child* draws on these interpretations, but it shifts the focus from the question of how Sweetness departs from standards of motherhood to the issue of how Morrison's representation of her prompts complex ethical judgments on readers' part. While the question of the character's motivation—her behaviour being conditioned by trauma, in these readings—remains central, my contribution expands knowledge on the novel by focusing on the specific narrative devices deployed by Morrison to situate her readers in an ethically nuanced position.

Sweetness' representation as a "bad mother" can be traced back to one major issue: her racism against her own daughter. Goldberg brilliantly analyzes the character's "internalized hierarchy of skin color",[15] which is repeatedly addressed in the text. The first reference to it appears as the baby is born, and she describes her skin colour in the following terms: "Midnight black. Sudanese black".[16] Immediately afterwards, she compares it with her own and her husband's, followed by an account of her family history, marked by her grandmother's and her own parents' passing, which granted them racial privilege: "because of my mother's skin color, she wasn't stopped from trying on hats in the department stores or using the ladies' room".[17] Sweetness' hatred of her daughter's "blue–black" skin colour is mentioned both by herself and by Bride: "the skin she hated"[18]; "Sweetness hated her for her black skin".[19] The issue of colorism features prominently in other novels by Morrison, with *Paradise* as paradigmatic example of its workings at collective level. Such collective dimension is also addressed by Sweetness in this novel in self-justifying terms:

> Some of you probably think it's a bad thing to group ourselves according to skin color—the lighter, the better—in social clubs, neighborhoods, churches, sororities, even colored schools. But how else can we hold on to a little dignity?.[20]

Yet, *God Help the Child* explores in depth the consequences of colorism within the family structure, and particularly through mother-daughter relations.[21]

A key aspect I intend to address is the role of judgment in the construction of Sweetness as a mother character in the novel. As Walker notes, "The reader is positioned as a judge over a cast of characters standing accused of the same crime: their inability (or unwillingness) to confront and take responsibility for the suffering of children in their care".[22] No one, though, comes under such rigorous scrutiny for her negligence as Sweetness. No one, moreover, tries to justify herself with greater emphasis: "But it's not my fault. It's not my fault. It's not my fault. It's not".[23] The hovering question my essay ultimately addresses is how is ethical judgment on Sweetness' mothering articulated in the novel.

[14]Schreiber, "The Power of Witnessing". See also Roldán Sevillano's PhD thesis, which draws on this line of interpretation too, by identifying Sweetness as a victim of transgenerational trauma. *Of Victims, Perpetrators and Implicated Subjects*, 254–5.
[15]Goldberg, 148.
[16]Morrison, *God Help,* 3.
[17]Ibid., 4.
[18]Ibid., 31.
[19]Ibid., 143.
[20]Ibid., 4.
[21]On colorism in *God Help the Child*, see also Wilson, "Raising the Inner Child"; Stave, "Skin Deep".
[22]Walker, n.p.
[23]Morrison, *God Help,* 7.

2. Mothers in Morrison's Work.

Paperback editions of Toni Morrison's *God Help the Child,* include as part of its paratextual material a backmatter synopsis starting with the words: "Sweetness wants to love her child, Bride, but she struggles to love her as a mother should". The synopsis then goes on to synthesise Bride's story of crisis and personal growth, which constitutes the text's narrative core. It seems symptomatic, however, that the backmatter synopsis follows the same logic as the novel itself regarding the role of the mother character in it. Although Sweetness is not the protagonist of the novel in a conventional sense, her presence is central to the plot. She is given the first and last word in the text, in chapters narrated in the first person.[24] Moreover, the words about her in the synopsis already point to a breach between what the character *should be* and what she actually is. It is precisely this gap that I set out to investigate in what follows, by interrogating the nature of the unfulfilled obligation implied in the modal verb "should"—How should a mother love? Who prescribes the nature of such motherly love?—and the undetermined character of Sweetness' deviation from it, implicit both in the idea of Sweetness *wanting* to love and on the notion that she *struggles* to comply with the standard of motherly love.

This textual fragment provides the opportunity to discuss the representation of mothers and motherhood in Morrison's novel. Sweetness stands as the most prominent mother character in the text, but her apparent failure to comply with a prescriptive model of motherhood is echoed in at least two other secondary characters: Rain's unnamed mother, who prostituted her from an early age,[25] and Queen, Booker's aunt, whose several children "hate her for some reason or another".[26] The three characters are mothers to estranged children who have been either rescued from them (Rain) or rejected by them (Bride, Queen's children). While Rain's mother is not given voice in the novel, and is morally condemned by Bride in explicit terms—"How could anybody do that to a child, any child, and one's own?"[27]—both Queen and Sweetness are given a chance for self-justification. Sweetness' first words in the text are in fact "It's not my fault. So you can't blame me".[28] The sense of a lack in her as a mother, a deviation from a pre-existing conception of how she should be in others' eyes—"*you* can't blame me"—is present from the very beginning of the text.

The representation of Sweetness needs to be further contextualised within the body of Morrison's work, in comparison to other mother characters in her fiction. It should be noted that the representation of mother figures in Morrison's work is exceedingly rich and complex. While *Beloved* may be mentioned as the text most clearly written from the point of view of the mother, the daughter's perspective is more common in novels like *Sula, Tar Baby,* or *God Help the Child*. Several of Morrison's novels feature nonconventional mothers who seem incapable of fitting into a prescribed role model associated to motherhood. These include Sweetness, but also Mrs. Breedlove in *The Bluest Eye,* Pilate in *Song of Solomon,* or May in *Love*. Furthermore, several of Morrison's mother

[24]On this regard, the novel follows a pattern found as well in *A Mercy* (2008), where the last pages of the novel are written in the first person by Florens' mother, in the form of an address to her daughter.
[25]Morrison, *God Help,* 101.
[26]Ibid., 169. See also Gallego, "Childhood Traumas, Journeys", 59, on the recurrence of 'bad mothers' in *God Help the Child*.
[27]Ibid., 101.
[28]Ibid., 3.

characters commit acts which seem incompatible with a protective role conventionally associated to motherhood: Sethe's killing of her baby daughter in *Beloved*, Florens' mother abandoning her as a child in *A Mercy* and Eva's mercy killing of her son Plum in *Sula* stand as the most prominent examples.

Scholarly work on motherhood in Morrison's work is abundant, and has recurrently analysed the subversion of prescriptive models of motherhood in her novels. Authors like O'Reilly, Eckard, Moore, and Baxter & Satz[29] point to the incompatibility between prescribed articulations of motherhood and the actual practice of "motherwork" as the root of dramatic conflict in Morrison's fiction: "Her work cultivates an examination of black motherhood that counters motherhood performed and advocated by the dominant culture".[30] O'Reilly, who has written extensively on the topic of motherhood in Morrison, elaborates:

> Morrison's fiction bespeaks the despair and rage of mothers who, in the face of racism and poverty, are not able to fulfill these essential tasks of motherwork. What is described in Morrison is not the successful completion of this work but a mother's arduous, usually desperate, struggle to protect and nurture her children. Consequently, novels such as *The Bluest Eye* and *Sula* describe a mother's struggle to preserve and nurture; they also convey the mother's grief and rage at not being able to do so effectively, because of both racism and the patriarchal institution of motherhood. The mothers' rage and grief emerge as the central and organizing theme and perspective of the narrative. (2004: 44)[31]

O'Reilly establishes a dichotomy between two models of motherhood in dialectical tension in Morrison's representations. A white sensitive model of motherhood[32] which would correspond to the natural mother ideal which was never available to African American women, and which constitutes the normative standard against which *all* experiences of motherhood are measured.[33] This is opposed by a preserving model of strict mothering, in which the mother abandons the loving, nurturing role for the sake of granting the survival of her offspring in a hostile environment, in near Darwinian fashion.[34]

The critical models proposed by O'Reilly, Baxter & Satz and Moore identify the social conditioning that shapes mother characters in Morrison's work in "the intersectional oppressions that create 'bad' mothers",[35] and point to how Morrison both "advocates the importance of mothering as she highlights the effects of loss and anguish caused in its absence".[36] Moore, whose work focuses on the nurturing maternal as an empowered and empowering figure[37] warns against a potential form of "victim blaming" lurking in criticism of Morrison's depictions:

[29]O'Reilly, *Toni Morrison and Motherhood*; Eckard, *Maternal Body and Voice in Toni Morrison*; Moore, *Maternal Metaphors of Power*; Baxter and Satz, *Toni Morrison*.
[30]Baxter and Satz, *Toni Morrison*, 1. See also Eckard, *Maternal Body and Voice in Toni Morrison*, 34.
[31]O'Reilly, *Toni Morrison and Motherhood*, 44. Braxton establishes the "outraged mother" as a central archetype in the African American tradition, representing the embodiment of values necessary to an endangered group, such as courage and sacrifice. Braxton, "Ancestral Presence".
[32]O'Reilly, *Toni Morrison and Motherhood*, 30–32
[33]Ibid., 123.
[34]Ibid., 32.
[35]Baxter and Satz, *Toni Morrison*, 3.
[36]Ibid., 2.
[37]Moore, *Maternal Metaphors of Power*, 233.

> Problematizing Morrison's maternal characters for the social and political pathology in society that she has them confront is akin to blaming the victim. Instead, the dysfunctional society is problematic because it makes motherhood and its natural rites of passage utterly impossible.[38]

This aligns with the evidence offered by Patricia Hill Collins on how "Framed through this prism of an imagined traditional family ideal, U.S. Black women's experiences and those of other women of color are typically deemed deficient".[39]

Yet, while I concur with their identification of the sociological causality involved in Morrison's representations of mothers who do not fall within prescribed roles, I perceive a key distinction could be made in the way she approaches the problem in different texts. Hence, I would identify three distinct narrative patterns or "types":[40]

(1) Subversive mothers who defy a prescribed model of motherhood, and openly refuse to comply with either strict parenting style in a racist context and with a white sensitive model. Pilate in *Song of Solomon* stands as the epitome of this type, although traces of it may be identified as well in the portrayal *in absentia* of Wild (*Jazz*). Often seen from the perspective of their offspring, they are perceived as failed mothers, precisely because their mothering style is incomprehensible in their social context. Even if they are eventually vindicated, justified in the text, they remain troubling figures. Critique comes from society, while they are "redeemed" by readers, who are led to appreciate the validity of their defiance to prescribed motherhood.[41]
(2) "Monstruous" mothers who commit acts which go against the moral codes of their social environments. Sethe (*Beloved*), Florens' mother (*A Mercy*), and Eva (*Sula*) exemplify this type.[42] These are mothers who abandon or kill their children, but whose actions are eventually revealed in the text as acts of love. The crux of these characters is to sacrifice the appearance of fitting into a prescribed model of motherhood for the sake of a greater, deeper form of motherly love which is shown as paradoxical and counterintuitive. Critique comes from society in the form of condemnation for what is perceived as a crime, and their ethical predicament is transferred to the reader's judgment in the form of a dilemma. With these characters, Morrison invites complex reflection on the paradoxes involved in ethics, love and sacrifice.
(3) Struggling mothers who follow a strict motherhood model in trying to help their children survive, like Mrs. Breedlove (*The Bluest Eye*), Sweetness, and May

[38]Ibid., 292.
[39]Collins, *Black Feminist Though*, 47.
[40]Note that my focus here is on characters whose mothering is perceived as anomalous and/or pernicious by either their children or their community (at diegetic level) or by the reader (at extradiegetic level). For a detailed analysis of the nurturing, empowering maternal figure, also abundant in Morrison's fictional universe, see Moore, *Maternal Metaphors of Power*, 233–27.
[41]See Collins, *Black Feminist Thought*, 75, on the "bad Black mother" figure in American culture.
[42]I include Florens' mother from *A Mercy* in this group because, like Sethe or Eva, she incurs into what Mogenstern calls "ethical violence" for the sake of her child. However, as Morgenstern notes, the accent is placed, in this novel, on the divergence between the readers' and the daughter's perception of the mother's ethical decision: "*A Mercy* is the story of a mother's choice and sacrifice that her daughter will never adequately read, unlike the reader who reads the whole text and then overhears the mother's address". Morgenstern, "Maternal love/Maternal Violence". The social consideration of her action is mainly evinced in the text through Jakob Vaark's perception that her mother was just "throwing away" a child she had no use for. Morrison, *A Mercy*, 34. See also Morgenstern, 17.

(*Love*):[43] eventually, their parenting style, conditioned by white supremacist thinking and the need to keep one's head down in a racist and sexist environment, has traumatic effects in children taught submission as the only response to abuse. These are mothers who think they are doing an excellent job, unaware of their interiorisation of racist ideology, and who are willing to exculpate themselves from the negative side effects of their mothering. Both society and themselves sanction their mothering as a valid one. Critique comes from the reader's ethical judgment, based on perception of their traumatised children.

In all three cases, the intersectional oppressions identified by Baxter & Satz works as trigger conditioning characters' behaviour toward their children. As Goldberg observes,

> Although these characters perform actions toward their children that readers may quickly see as morally reprehensible—be it killing an adult child, infanticide, or emotional abuse—Morrison's contextualization of these characters render them too complex to be reduced to a single ethical judgment of an individual.[44]

Yet, the social perception and sanction of their motherwork within the diegetic world varies significantly across the spectrum, and the narrative articulation of each type, constructed through management of point of view and narrative progression, determines very different responses on the part of the reader in terms of ethical judgment.

In my analysis, I identify Sweetness as belonging to the third type or narrative pattern, to the extent that her motherwork is not identified by her social environment as "monstruous", but it emerges as having harmful effects on her daughter on the long run. I thus dissent from Goldberg's parallel between Sweetness and Sethe, both of whom he sees as "appear[ing] before readers having committed material violence in attempting to exercise maternal ethics".[45] While he points to the nature of each one's actions as the basis for distinguishing between their cases, I would rather argue that it is rather grounded on Morrison's construction of social and readerly judgment. In *Beloved*, Sethe's act is nearly universally condemned by those around her, including the white slaveowners, the black community and Paul D, whereas readers are afforded a view of the situation that allows us to understand Sethe's predicament and to conclude, with Morrison, that "it was absolutely the right thing to do".[46] In *God Help the Child,* the lack of negative judgment by society within the diegetic world is countered by the daughter's perspective of Sweetness, and by the reader's ethical judgments based on it. In other words, we may tentatively claim that Sweetness does not *seem* a bad mother, but the narrative *reveals* her as being one. She is, so to say, a covert monstrous mother.

3. Sociological Matrix. Motherhood, Mothering, Black Parenting.

As Paula G. Eckard argues, "In general, maternal subjectivity, which presents the experiences of pregnancy, childbirth, breast-feeding, and motherhood from the mother's

[43]Moore, *Maternal Metaphors of Power*, 283, 298, identifies these three characters as archetypes of the "bad mother" in Morrison.
[44]Goldberg, "From Sweetness to Toya Graham", 140.
[45]Ibid., 146.
[46]Rothstein, "Toni Morrison, In Her New Novel, Defends Women".

perspective, has not had a visible place in the history of written culture".[47] The opening chapter from *God Help the Child* seems written to counteract such absence, by offering a visible narrative of several of those elements—childbirth, breast-feeding and the education of the child—from the mother's perspective. The nature of such account by Sweetness deviates significantly from idealised models which put the stress on the selfless, nurturing mother figure. Thus, the moment of childbirth is narrated in terms stressing the mother's lack of active participation in it: "... an hour after they pulled her out from between my legs".[48] Breastfeeding is soon rejected by the mother on the basis of estrangement from her child: "... nursing her was like having a pickaninny sucking my teat. I went to bottle-feeding soon as I got home".[49] Education, finally, is narrated by Sweetness in terms that repeatedly emphasise how her motherwork is conditioned by the dangers she feels her daughter will be exposed to as a consequence of her skin colour: "Her color is a cross she will always carry".[50] On page 6, Sweetness relates how she asks her daughter not to address her as her mother, with the argument that "It was safer". An echo of this is to be found in a later chapter, narrated from Bride's perspective, as she recalls the apartment they lived in during her childhood: "it would be hard finding a location in another safe, meaning mixed, neighborhood".[51] A question may be posed as to whose safety is being advocated, particularly as we read on Sweetness' explanation: "Being that black and having what I think are too-thick lips calling me 'Mama' would confuse people".[52] Just a few lines earlier, Sweetness has fantasised with the idea that people might think, upon seeing them together, that she "could have been the babysitter if our skin colors were reversed".[53]

The opening chapter of the novel, narrated by Sweetness, offers ample evidence of how her mothering style has been determined by the sociological matrix of racism. Thus, while Sweetness struggles to justify herself as a good mother trying to protect her child in a racist environment, the reader is allowed to glimpse into the devastating effects that her interiorisation of colorism has on the long run. bell hooks writes specifically about the experience of black mothering in the influential essay "Revolutionary Parenting" (1984). hooks' essay may be understood as a response to how second wave feminism in the United States tended to codify women's liberation in opposition to the "natural mother" ideal. She introduces the racial dimension into the feminist debate on the institutional articulation of motherhood, thus adopting an intersectional approach. hooks calls attention to how the social context for most African American women in the USA prevented such tension between work and motherhood as incompatible terms, and recodifies motherhood, and the context of family, as humanising labour which reaffirms identity. Black women, she claims are rarely represented as loving, nurturing figures, so that the "natural mother" role, which the white feminists rejected because of its narrowing of women's capabilities, is vindicated as an empowering tool.[54]

[47]Eckard, *Maternal Body and Voice*, 23.
[48]Morrison, *God Help*, 3.
[49]Ibid., 5.
[50]Ibid., 7.
[51]Ibid., 54.
[52]Ibid., 6.
[53]Ibid.
[54]For as more general account of the normalization of a family model in the USA that clashes against the reality of most African American families, see Collins, 47.

Going back to the dichotomy established by Andrea O'Reilly between two models of motherhood in dialectical tension in Morrison's representations, we may observe that the white sensitive model of motherhood would correspond to the natural mother ideal which, as hooks argued, was never available to African American women. This is opposed by a model of strict parenting, in which the mother abandons the loving, nurturing role for the sake of granting the survival of her offspring. These models could be recodified through the opposition between sentimentalism vs. materialism. This is at the heart of E. Frances White's observation about the impossibility of ignoring the mother's voice in African American women's writing: "How dare we admit the psychological battles that need to be fought with the very women who taught us to survive in this racist and sexist world? We would feel like ungrateful traitors".[55]

Sweetness, in her own words, is precisely one of those mothers keen on teaching her daughter survival:

> Things got better but I had to be very careful. Very careful in how I raised her. I had to be very strict. Lula Ann needed to learn how to behave, how to keep her head down and not to make trouble;[56]

"See if I hadn't trained Lula Ann properly she wouldn't have known to always cross the street and avoid white boys".[57] One could consider, however, the extent to which mothers who teach their daughters submission as a strategy for survival are reproducing, because having interiorised, the logics of white supremacist ideology. As Collins argues, "a mother can foster her children's oppression if she teaches them to believe in their own inferiority".[58] This would amount to admitting the inevitability of the material conditions in which black women have to be raised.

Both in *The Bluest Eye* and in *God Help the Child*, Morrison deals with the problem of interiorised colorism in connection to motherhood. But although Morrison may be critical with such interiorisation, she confronts her reader with the difficulties of finding an alternative to such apparent defeatism on the part of the mothers. It is in this sense that her representation of motherhood can be said to articulate a constant ethical dilemma, identified by Collins: "US Black mothers of daughters face a troubling dilemma [...] Mothers may have ensured their daughters' physical survival, but at the high cost of their emotional destruction".[59] While the readers' ethical judgment on Florens' mother (*A Mercy*) and Sethe (*Beloved*) may be transformed as a consequence of our reinscribing their behaviour as truly ethical despite appearance of paradox, the cases of Mrs. Breedlove and Sweetness seem to me more complex, precisely because they offer less extreme versions of the paradox of monstruous motherhood. With them, Morrison seems to be breaking a major taboo regarding the representation of motherhood, as their anger is directly turned on their children because of the threat to survival they pose.

[55]White, "Listening to the Voices of Black Feminism".
[56]Morrison, *God Help*, 7.
[57]Ibid., 41.
[58]Collins, *Black Feminist Thought*, 50–51.
[59]Ibid., 183.

4. The Mother-Daughter Plot, and Its Impossibility.

In the Introduction to *The Mother/Daughter Plot*, Marianne Hirsch writes that, in order to know about Jocasta's story in *Oedipus King*, "we would have to *begin* with the mother".[60] To begin with the mother is precisely what Morrison does in *God Help the Child*. This is a text otherwise constructed from a "daughterly" perspective from its very title, as it alludes to the "child" as a figure of vulnerability and precariousness in need of divine assistance. In this sense, the novel seems to comply with a tendency identified by Daly and Reddy in texts which do "begin with the mother in her own right, from her own perspective", but "seldom hold fast to a maternal perspective; further when texts do maintain this perspective, readers and critics tend to suppress the centrality of mothering".[61] Yet, I would argue that Morrison's management of narrative structure complicates in significant ways any attempt to read the mother out of the text.

A detailed analysis of *God Help the Child*'s textual organisation may be quite productive for the identification of Morrison's management of perspective in it. This novel features a narrative pattern which Toni Morrison perfected over the years, from *Paradise* to the sequence of shorter, later novels including *A Mercy, Love,* and *Home*. All these texts present a complex narrative structure combining first and third person narration that helps reconstruct a multigenerational, multiperspectival story roughly corresponding to what Corinne Bancroft calls "braided narrative".[62] Here, chapters titled after characters' names are written in the first person by such characters, alternating with long, untitled sections narrated in the third person. More specifically, the characters who are given first person chapters are Sweetness (3 chapters), Bride (4), Brooklyn (3), Sofia (2), and Rain (1). These are distributed unevenly throughout the text. All of Bride's chapters appear in Part I of the novel, while Sweetness' are sprinkled on different points (pages 3–7, 41–43, 176–178). An additional peculiarity of this structure may be observed by comparing the length of such characters. While all the character-chapters are 3–4 pages long on average, Bride's chapters are typically longer (between 12 and 15 pages, except for the last one, which is only 4 pages long).

Moreover, the novel's division into four parts is far from symmetrical. While the first part is narrated entirely through first person chapters by four of the five aforementioned characters, the remaining three parts are for the most part narrated in the third person. Part II includes a short chapter narrated by Sofia (76–77) and ends with another short one by Rain (the only one in the entire novel), while Part III is entirely narrated in the third person. Finally, Part IV opens with a chapter narrated by Brooklyn, just to shift into third person narration again. The very end of the novel is finally narrated by Sweetness, in the closing chapter. Regarding the third person sections, focalisation in them is almost always on Bride, except for Part III, where the character focalised is Booker, and again for a brief passage on pages 159–161.

All in all, the narrative structure sketched above privileges Bride's perspective in the novel through an array of narrative devices, from the amount of text devoted to her to the use of focalisation and first-person narration. Here, as noted by Walton

[60]Hirsch, *The Mother/Daughter Plot*, 5.
[61]Brenda O'Daly and Maureen T. Reddy, *Narrating Mothers: Theorizing Maternal Subjectivities* (Knoxville, TN: University of Tennessee Press, 1991), 2-3.
[62]Bancroft, "The Braided Narrative". See also Ryan, "The Modes of Narrativity".

Muyumba, the secondary character-narrators work as dissonant voices which foreground the main themes of Bride's coming of age story: "Like Bride, for instance, all three ancillary characters carry burdensome childhood baggage and have charged relationships with their mothers".[63] While previous novels by Morrison may be said to illustrate what Fredric Jameson has called "the waning of protagonicity",[64] *God Help the Child* clearly marks a return to the patterns defined by the *Bildungsroman* tradition, in which the story of personal growth of a young character determines novelistic form.[65] Thus, this could be said to be a novel told from a "daughterly perspective", borrowing Hirsch's term, apparently structured through "daughter-centricity".[66]

This is further evinced by the fact that even in the chapters narrated by the mother by the novel, the object of attention is still the daughter. The first chapter offers a brief reflection on Sweetness' family history, in which passing features prominently as a severing mechanism breaking up the continuity of the "motherline".[67] Other than that, the entire chapter revolves around the idea that there is something "really wrong" about the newly-born Bride (then Lula Ann).[68] Her birth upsets Sweetness' mental stability, through embarrassment first, and the risk of madness afterward, as the idea of Sweetness going crazy is mentioned three times on page 5. Sweetness openly blames her daughter for breaking up her marriage, when her husband leaves her: "It broke our marriage to pieces. We had three good years together but then she was born he blamed me and treated Lula Ann like she was a stranger—more than that, an enemy".[69]

The second chapter narrated by Sweetness is entirely focused on her job as a mother, with a clear exculpatory and self-justifying purpose:

> Oh, yeah, I feel bad sometimes about how I treated Lula Ann when she was little [...] See if I hadn't trained Lula Ann properly [...] But the lessons I taught her paid off because in the end she made me proud as a peacock.[70]

In spite of the fact that the story she tells about Lula Ann's participation in the trial against Sofia Huxley is tuned in to that proud mom role she attributes to herself, the final lines of the chapter go back to the exculpatory rhetoric: "I wasn't a bad mother, you have to know that, but I may have done some hurtful things to my only child because I had to protect her".[71] Her initially confessed repugnance at the colour of her daughter's skin is here entirely transferred to others, the "white trash" from whom she allegedly tries to protect her. A key moment in this chapter articulates Sweetness' contradictions regarding her daughter: "At first I couldn't see past all that black to know who she was and just plain love her. But I do. I really do. I think she understands now. I think so". What follows stands in stark contrast with this attempt to bridge the gap between

[63]Muyumba, "Lady Sings the Blues".
[64]Jameson, *The Antinomies of Realism*, 95.
[65]Woloch, *The One vs. the Many*, 2, has written on the asymmetry of attention to key characters in a narrative: "Narrative meaning takes shape in the dynamic flux of attention and neglect toward the various characters who are locked within the same story but have radically different positions within the narrative". Woloch, *The One vs. the Many*.
[66]Daly and Reddy, *Narrating Mothers*, 2. See also Podnieks and O'Reilly, *Textual Mothers/Maternal Texts*, 2.
[67]O'Reilly, *Toni Morrison and Motherhood*, 85.
[68]Morrison, *God Help*, 3.
[69]Ibid., 5.
[70]Ibid., 41–42.
[71]Ibid., 43.

mother and daughter, as Sweetness admits the estrangement from her: "She sends me money and stuff every now and then, but I ain't seen her in I don't know how long".[72]

When she is once more given voice in the closing chapter of the book, such estrangement is confirmed, and any illusion as to Bride's understanding of her mother's love discarded: "So I guess I'm still the bad parent being punished forever till the day I die for doing the well-intended and, in fact, necessary way I brought her up. I know she hates me".[73] At this point, Sweetness is living in a nursing home, replicating a recurrent *topos* in Morrison's fiction.[74] In her reminiscence about bringing up Bride, she is revealed to contradict herself, by talking about regret—"If I sound irritable, ungrateful, part of it is because underneath is regret. All the little things I didn't do or did wrong"[75]—but simultaneously trying to appropriate Bride's success in life, as an outcome of her upbringing: "Still, some of my schooling must have rubbed off. See how she turned out? A rich career girl. Can you beat it?".[76]

As we read Bride's side of the story, it becomes clear that, even if Bride may have come to understand her mother's motives in treating her the way she did, she has not forgiven, least of all forgotten. At no point is Sweetness' work as a mother given a hint of appreciation on Bride's part. The first time Sweetness is mentioned by Bride in the text is in the second chapter narrated by her, in Part I. s she recalls the moment of her testimony in the trial against Sofia Huxley, Bride recalls herself looking for her mother's reaction, which is described in positive terms signalling her approval: "I glanced at Sweetness; she was smiling like I've never seen her smile before".[77] Already in this initial reference, we register the fact that Bride refers to her mother with her first name, rather than as "mother", "mum", "mama" ... This actually matches Sweetness' own statement, in the opening chapter, that she "told her to call me 'Sweetness' instead of 'Mother' or 'Mama'".[78] Sweetness' reaction in the aftermath of the trial is depicted in Bride's words as "kind of motherlike".[79] This is the only time she comes close to referring to her as mother. Her narrative recurrently points to Sweetness' deviations from the prescribed motherly role, an aspect emphasised by negative syntactic and semantic patterns. When she holds Bride's hand upon leaving the courthouse, she observes "She never did that before and it surprised me as much as it pleased me because I always knew she didn't like touching me".[80] Later, Bride observes "Sweetness never attended parent-teacher meetings or volleyball games";[81] refers to her mother as "a mother who avoided physical contact whenever possible";[82] and evokes memories of impossible mother-daughter bonding:

> Bride quickly dashed a bright memory of Sweetness humming some blues song while washing panty hose in the sink, little Lula Ann hiding behind the door to hear her. How nice it would have been if mother and daughter could have sung together.[83]

[72]Ibid.
[73]Ibid., 177.
[74]See Moore, *Maternal Metaphors of Power*, 299.
[75]Morrison, *God Help*, 177.
[76]Ibid., 178.
[77]Ibid., 31.
[78]Ibid., 6.
[79]Ibid., 32.
[80]Ibid., 31.
[81]Ibid., 35.
[82]Ibid., 79.
[83]Ibid., 87.

Against the backdrop of such scene, the rest of Bride's memories of her mother are connected to a permanent state of fear: "When fear rules, obedience is the only survival choice";[84] "Like the atmosphere in her mother's house where she never knew the right thing to do or say or remember what the rules were";[85] "too weak, too scared to defy Sweetness".[86] The closest Bride ever gets to concede Sweetness' motherly role is when she compares it to Rain's relation to her own mother, who threw the child out of her house: "Why would anybody do that to a child? Bride wondered. Even Sweetness, who for years couldn't bear to look at or touch her, never threw her out".[87] She does it in a syntactical formulation which establishes Sweetness at a very high point in the scale of "bad mothering", but which does not represent an absolute highest point, which would be occupied by Rain's mother.

Scholarly work on the representation of motherhood in African American women's fiction repeatedly emphasises how Morrison and her contemporaries enact in their work the "recovery of the mother by the daughter".[88] Hirsch, Podnieks and O'Reilly and others identify a typical daughter-centric pattern in which the rebellious daughter finds a way back to the mother, reclaiming and vindicating her.[89] *God Help the Child*, like the earlier *Tar Baby*, sets out to retrace this pattern, only to upset it, as an impossible reconciliation with the mother. Thus, as we read that Bride announces to her mother in a letter that she is to have a baby herself, it can hardly be suggested that the motherline may be restored through intergenerational communication. When Bride sends her mother a letter to let her know she will soon become a grandmother, there seems to be a strong dissonance emerging from the contrast between Bride's words in her letter, Sweetness reaction to the news, and the nurse's reaction as perceived by Sweetness. Bride's note first hints at reconciliation and an expectation of empathy on Sweetness' part: "I'm too too thrilled and hope you are too".[90] Sweetness' reaction, however, removes any sentimentality from the news, and is codified in terms that suggest opportunism and even strategy on Bride's part: "Now she's pregnant. Good move, Lula Ann".[91] Finally, as Sweetness' reaction focuses exclusively on Bride's motherhood, it offers a sharp contrast with the nurse's, which underscores her future role as grandmother, a role Sweetness herself does not seem to appreciate: "Her smile and her compliments were fit for someone about to be crowned".[92]

Eventually, therefore, the reconciliation between mother and child is thwarted in the text, and the way back to the mother never accomplished. In its place, the risk of potential repetition of earlier mothers' mistakes is suggested by Sweetness' final words, which are directly addressed to Bride: "Listen to me. You are about to find out what it takes, how the world is, how it works and how it changes when you are a parent".[93]

[84]Ibid., 32.
[85]Ibid., 78.
[86]Ibid., 79.
[87]Ibid., 101.
[88]Podnieks and O'Reilly, *Textual Mothers/Maternal Texts*, 10.
[89]Ibid., 8.
[90]Morrison, *God Help*, 176.
[91]Ibid., 178.
[92]Ibid., 176.
[93]Ibid., 178.

5. Character Narration, Ethical Judgment and Narrative Progression.

As we realise that the narrative does not allow for an enactment of actual or symbolic reconciliation between Sweetness and Bride, so that the mother's perspective would somehow be incorporated into the daughter's, we may turn our attention to the issue of how ethical judgment of Sweetness' role as a mother is articulated in the text. Roxane Gay introduces the idea of the mother's impossible predicament when she writes: "This is what makes it so difficult to judge Sweetness's choices. She should know better, but it is painfully clear her choices have been shaped by the realities of being black in a white world".[94] This premise about the difficulty to judge Sweetness in a clear, definitive way is to be addressed in connection to two key questions: Where does this difficulty come from? And how is it established in the text?

In the previous section, textual evidence on how Bride's chapters as character-narrator offer a negative judgment of Sweetness' mothering has been provided. From her perspective, we may conclude, Sweetness has been a bad mother, and remains unredeemed in her daughter's eyes. The question persists, however, as to whether Bride's judgment on her mother succeeds in persuading the reader. To the extent that the text allows us to read not only Bride's version but also Sweetness', the text's establishment of an ethical stance becomes multifaceted, complex. This relates to what James Phelan calls "a layered ethical situation",[95] in which the ethical dimension of characters' actions stands in complex relation to the narrator's presentation of such actions, in turn conveying certain attitudes toward the subject matter that are to be picked up by the audience.[96] In this case, contrasting both characters' versions of their relationship offers relevant clues that point to the reasons why it may actually be difficult for the reader to fully endorse Bride's view.

A major distinction between the narrative style of the two sets of chapters narrated by Sweetness and Bride can be traced by considering Sweetness' as instances of "lyric narrative". Bride's narrative is dynamic, whereas Sweetness' is static. Her story is done, her work as a mother finished. Bride's story of personal development must happen in the wake of Sweetness' motherwork. Hers is a story of change, while Sweetness' sections respond to the logic of lyric revelation.[97] They share at least one of the characteristics identified by Phelan in this type of narration: "the character narrator does not undergo any substantial change within the temporal frame of the main action; instead, the text focuses on revealing the dimensions of the character narrator's current situation".[98] By contrast, Bride's chapters focus mostly on the diegetic present and tend to focus on events which have recently taken place, such as Booker's departure or her confrontation with Sofia Huxley. Even when she reminisces about the distant past, particularly her childhood, this is directly connected to her present situation.

The occasion for the telling in Sweetness' chapters is not explained in the text, but the narratee (you) is explicit. Hence, the reader may wonder who this "you" is meant to be, whether it refers to another character within the diegetic world, to whom she would

[94]Gay, "*God Help the Child*".
[95]Phelan, *Living to Tell about It*, 20.
[96]For a detailed description of this model, see Phelan, *Living to Tell about It*, 20–21.
[97]Phelan, *Living to Tell about It*, 30.
[98]Ibid., 159.

be talking, or whether it rather addresses the implied reader directly, thus enacting a metaleptic turn that puts Sweetness in a more direct communication with the extradiegetic world. This is in turn connected to the issue of her motivation for the telling. Considering her first words in the text, we could affirm that this is, quite explicitly, self-exculpation. A dual focalisation is established in the text, through which Sweetness the (present) narrator justifies Sweetness the (past) character. Thus, her discourse ranges between self-justification ("The well-intended and, in fact, necessary way I brought her up"[99]), regret, minimising her faults ("All the little things I didn't do or did wrong"[100]), self-censorship ("at first I thought of… No. I have to push those memories away"[101]), and claiming mental transient derangement ("I went crazy for a minute …"[102]). The diversity and reiteration of such self-exculpatory strategies work against her case, I would argue, as their intensity invites the readers to perceive her as untrustworthy.

Bride's narrative, on the other hand, works as an accusation, as evidence against the mother, and contributes to setting the readers' judgment against Sweetness. Why? Both because she is clearly presented as the victim of her mother's neglect, on the plane of actions, and because of the prominence she is given in the narrative, which invites the reader to adopt the daughterly perspective. Bride's narrative mode is dominated by her resentment about her mother, her developmental trauma, and her longing for love and contact. All of these elements, in turn, help shape her narrative as grounded on the depiction of her maturation process that evolves from the overcoming of the former aspects to the achievement of the latter.

Beyond the fact of the contraposition of the two opposed narratives, readerly judgment is also shaped through the dynamics of narrative progression. The notion of progression, we should note, affects both the sequence of events narrated as well as the readers' judgment based on it. As Katherine Saunders Nash argues, "Readerly judgments, especially those that occur early in a narrative, are necessarily revisable".[103] Thus, "just as there is a progression of events there is a progression of audience response to those events, a progression rooted in the twin activities of observing and judging".[104] An examination of narrative progression in connection to ethical judgment may illuminate the masterly manipulation of reader's judgment on Morrison's part.

The opening of the novel presents Sweetness' racism abruptly, in a way that suggests the readers will be more likely to judge her harshly. No background to the character has been given yet that may justify her actions or decisions, and the missing information on details and circumstances works against her. Bride's perspective works as middle of the narrative progression. At this point, the knowledge we acquire is still working against Sweetness, reinforcing readers' initial impression. When does our judgment begin to change, then? I would say this happens through what Phelan calls "lyric progression", in which "our judgments and emotions focus not on characters' choices and what they mean for what does and does not happen to them but rather on the progressive revelation

[99]Morrison, *God Help*, 177.
[100]Ibid.
[101]Ibid.
[102]Ibid., 5.
[103]Saunders Nash, "Narrative Structure".
[104]Phelan, *Living to Tell about It*, 162.

of the characters and their static situations".[105] In *God Help the Child*, four narrative elements contribute to such ethical progression:

(1) Secondary stories about other bad mothers in the novel, which set the basis for comparison, establishing a scale of "bad mothering". This happens first with Rain, so that Bride is led to admit that her mother was worse than Sweetness,[106] and later with Queen, whose motherwork is questioned in conversation with Booker: While Bride defends her, claiming she loves her children, Booker suggests there may be evidence that she is also a bad mother.[107]
(2) Bride's perception of her mother is undermined by Booker and Queen, who simply talk about a "complicated relationship with her mother"[108] or mention her "complaining about her mother",[109] thus downplaying her judgment of Sweetness as a bad mother.
(3) Bride herself being said to have overcome her relation to her mother, in very mild terms: "No longer forced to relive, no, outlive the disdain of her mother and the abandonment of her father".[110]
(4) Sweetness' indictment on Bride's upcoming maternity: "You are about to find out what it takes, how the world is, how it works, and how it changes when you are a parent".[111] The suggestion is that the same mistakes will be made, that everyone is conditioned, as a parent, by the social environment.

The difficulties to judge Sweetness in a neat, definitive way come, I contend, both from the realisation of her sociological conditionings imposed by gender- and race-based discrimination, and from Morrison's magisterial management of narrative technique, which simultaneously affirms and undermines each character's ethical stance. In *God Help the Child*, her management of perspective and progression leads not so much to the reversal of initial ethical judgments into their opposite, but to the simultaneous entertaining of two possible readings.

6. Conclusion: The Mother's Dilemma and the Reader's Judgment.

Discussing the relevance of ethics in narrative, Phelan argues the following:

> One of the remarkable features of narrative is that it can take an action that we would conventionally regard as ethically sound or ethically deficient, and through the details of its treatment in the narrative, either activate that conventional judgment or reject in in favor of a different and even opposite judgment.[112]

The second possibility falls within the scope of what critics like J. Hillis Miller (2011: 246-7) or Derek Attridge have identified as the actual realm of ethics, following Derrida in his

[105]Ibid., 10.
[106]Morrison, *God Help*, 101.
[107]Ibid., 169–70.
[108]Ibid., 134.
[109]Ibid., 143.
[110]Ibid., 162.
[111]Ibid., 178.
[112]Phelan, *Living to Tell about It*, 161.

theorisation of ethics as precisely grounded on the excess of responsibility which goes beyond the "specific obligations governing concrete situations in a given social context",[113] what Phelan calls activating conventional judgment. This is what grants ethical action an "initiatory, inaugural" dimension,[114] one which exceeds such conventional judgment for the sake of an unexpected one. The simultaneous perception of those two potential judgments, standing in tension with each other, is what Morrison achieves in *God Help the Child* regarding the mother's predicament.

Critical readings of the novel tend to emphasise Sweetness' unrepentance as evidence of her static moral position and her inability to undergo an ethical transformation in the novel. Walker refers to Sweetness as one who chooses "self-righteousness" when confronted with her responsibility in Bride's traumatic upbringing.[115] Wilson similarly comments on her being unapologetic, even as she reluctantly admits to being a "bad mother".[116] Simultaneously, however, critics identify in Sweetness the *topos* of the mother's impossible predicament. Goldberg underscores two key aspects about Morrison's articulation of Sweetness: First, that she is perfectly aware of the harmful effects her mothering has (note her allusion to "What you do to children matters"[117]). And second, that "Sweetness does not let the reader forget the stakes of racial subjection in accounting for her own mothering of Bride".[118]

Goldberg argues that within a racist system, the mother's call to protect her children becomes a problematic task leading mothers to paradoxical use of violence against those meant to be protected: "if the ethical demand of 'motherhood' is to protect children, then Black mothers in the U.S., insofar as they remain beyond the purview of 'protection', are always acting to fulfill an impossible ethical demand".[119] This is acknowledged, at large, sociological scale by Patricia Hill Collins: "US Black mothers of daughters face a troubling dilemma [...] Mothers may have ensured their daughters' physical survival, but at the high cost of their emotional destruction".[120] Goldberg elaborates further in identifying the auto-immunitary rationale of Sweetness' mothering: "it is in this very effort to protect her daughter that her daughter experiences most powerfully the violence of racism".[121] Morgenstern uses the term "maternal ethics" in a specific sense to refer to the paradoxical predicament of the mother's call to protect her children, assuming what Attridge calls responsibility *for* the other.[122] The risk of "ethical violence", Morgenstern argues, is present whenever one assumes such absolute responsibility for someone else's life. Thus, she argues that "Morrison's mothers also make traumatically isolating choices that they will never be able to explain to their daughters. These mothers will never be recognized by their daughters for their profound acts of love".[123]

[113]Attridge, *The Singularity of Literature*, 127.
[114]Miller, *The Conflagration of Community*, 246.
[115]Walker, n.p.
[116]Wilson, "Raising the Inner Child", 43.
[117]Morrison, *God Help*, 43.
[118]Goldberg, "From Sweetness to Toya Graham", 147.
[119]Ibid., 141.
[120]Collins, *Black Feminist Thought*, 183.
[121]Goldberg, "From Sweetness to Toya Graham", 149.
[122]Morgenstern, "Maternal love/Maternal Violence", 10; Attridge, *The Singularity of Literature*, 123–4. Compare Morgenstern's use to Moore's (5), who uses it in a more general sense referring to "fostering caregiving in the community".
[123]Morgenstern, "Maternal love/Maternal Violence", 23.

Goldberg argues, regarding Sweetness: "there is no analysis of Sweetness that can escape or disentangle the character's ethics from the realities of racism. To reduce Sweetness' colourism to a personal failing is to fail to account for the structuring forces of that colourism".[124] Through the analysis of the sociological matrix in which Morrison's representation of Sweetness is inscribed, I have tried to provide precisely such account of the structuring force of colorism, and racism in general. By attending to how ethical judgment is constructed in this novel, we realise that limiting Sweetness to sociological determinism would be equally reductive, for it would miss the complexity of Morrison's genuinely ethical double vision.[125] The text starts from the earlier models of mother-daughter relationship in Morrison's *oeuvre* but complicates them in significant ways, eventually leading us to the realisation of ethical *aporia*. At the end of the novel, readers do not find themselves in a position to exonerate Sweetness, but we may have come to the realisation that the black mother's predicament in a racist society is an impossible one.

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[124]Goldberg, "From Sweetness to Toya Graham", 149.

[125]I borrow the term "double vision" from Ryan, "Contested Visions/Double-Vision", 605, who uses the term in reference to a process of transformation of prior interpretation by allowing an additional meaning which does transform, but not erase, the opposing signification. Ryan, "Contested Visions/Double-Vision".

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